

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Legal Operations and Compliance English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For legal operations staff, compliance managers, contract managers, policy owners, audit teams, investigation coordinators, privacy operations staff, and risk professionals.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

approval path

The sequence of people or steps needed to authorize a decision.

attestation

A formal confirmation that a statement or requirement has been acknowledged or met.

audit

A systematic examination of evidence against defined requirements or criteria.

confidentiality

Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

contract intake

Collecting and routing the information needed to begin contract-related work.

control

A process, approval, check, or technical safeguard designed to reduce risk.

culture

Shared patterns of behavior and expectations within a group, with variation among individuals.

data processing

Operations performed on data, such as collection, storage, transformation, or analysis.

data subject request

Request from an individual to access, correct, delete, restrict, or otherwise exercise rights over personal data.

due diligence

Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding, investment, or decision.

evidence

Information that supports or challenges a claim or conclusion.

exception

An item that differs from an expected rule or normal processing path.

governance

Decision structure defining roles, rights, approvals, controls, and accountability.

hotline

A designated channel for raising concerns or seeking assistance.

monitoring

Repeatedly observing information to track conditions or detect changes.

non-retaliation

Requirement that people are not punished or disadvantaged for making a good-faith report, complaint, or participation in an investigation.

personal data

Information relating to an identified or identifiable person under the relevant legal definition.

policy

Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior.

process owner

The person accountable for how a defined process operates and improves.

reinforcement

Follow-up practice, reminders, or support that helps learning or behavior persist.

remediation

Work to correct a problem or reduce its effects; in environmental work, addressing contamination.

retention

Keeping customers, users, staff, or records over a stated period; specify which meaning applies.

risk acceptance

An authorized decision to retain a stated risk under specified conditions.

risk committee

A group responsible for reviewing defined risk matters and related decisions.

role-based training

Instruction tailored to the tasks and responsibilities of a particular role.

sample

A selected part of a population or material used for examination or analysis.

template

A reusable document or structure used as a starting point for consistent work.

third-party risk

Risk arising from relationships with outside providers or partners.

triage

Sorting issues by urgency, severity, risk, owner, and next action.

vendor questionnaire

A structured request for information used to evaluate a supplier's capabilities or risks.

verification

Checking whether specified requirements have been met.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Contract Intake and Workflow

A contract intake request says "urgent" but omits the agreement type, business owner, and required decision date.

Could you confirm the agreement type, business owner, and reason for the requested date? That will help the team route and prioritize the request using the actual business need.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Policy Implementation and Controls

A policy has been published, but nobody has identified who performs the related check or keeps the evidence.

Publishing the policy is one step. We also need to identify who performs the check, how often, and where its evidence is recorded so the process can operate consistently.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Compliance Audits and Evidence

An auditor requests records for a specific period. A team proposes sending a current screenshot with no date context.

Could we provide evidence covering the requested period and identify its source? A current screenshot alone may not answer the historical question in the request.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Internal Investigations

A hotline report contains an allegation and the reporter's interpretation. The intake note presents both as established facts.

I'll distinguish the reported event from the reporter's interpretation and use neutral wording. The investigation process should establish findings; the intake note should not prejudge them.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Privacy Operations and Data Requests

A data request arrives with insufficient information to identify the requester or scope. Staff are unsure which workflow applies.

Could we confirm the request type and required verification through the privacy process? Let's identify the relevant information without assuming access or disclosure is already authorized.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Third-Party Risk and Due Diligence

Two vendors offer similar services. One handles more personal data and relies on additional subcontractors.

The service descriptions are similar, but the data handling differs. I'll make those differences visible in the due-diligence summary so the responsible team can assess the relevant risks and controls.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Training, Attestations, and Culture

Training completion is 98%, but employees still ask how to apply the policy to common situations.

Completion shows attendance or participation, not necessarily practical understanding. Let's add role-specific scenarios and check whether people can identify the appropriate action in their work.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Governance, Reporting, and Risk Committees

A risk committee tracker shows an action as complete because its plan was approved. Implementation evidence is still outstanding.

The plan is approved; implementation is not yet verified. I'll report those stages separately and identify the evidence needed before the committee treats the action as complete.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Courts: glossary of legal terms

<https://www.uscourts.gov/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Legal Operations and Compliance English

Professional audience: legal operations staff, compliance managers, contract managers, policy owners, audit teams, investigation coordinators, privacy operations staff, and risk professionals

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Contract Intake and Workflow

Original fictional case: A contract intake request says "urgent" but omits the agreement type, business owner, and required decision date.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: contract intake: Collecting and routing the information needed to begin contract-related work. / template: A reusable document or structure used as a starting point for consistent work. / approval path: The sequence of people or steps needed to authorize a decision. / triage: Sorting issues by urgency, severity, risk, owner, and next action.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you confirm the agreement type, business owner, and reason for the requested date? That will help the team route and prioritize the request using the actual business need.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level